

# MATERA — THE SASSI

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### CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE FIRST LOOK

Stop here.

Don't check your phone yet. Don't look for the shot to take. Just look.

What you see in front of you exists nowhere else on earth. Thousands of homes carved into rock, stacked along the wall of a ravine, one above the other like rows in a theatre. The roof of one house is the courtyard of the one above. The courtyard of one house is the roof of the one below.

This city is seven thousand years old. That's not a figure of speech. Seven thousand years of continuous life, uninterrupted, from prehistory to today. It is one of the oldest continuously inhabited places on earth.

My name is Rosa. I was born here in 1948, in a cave in Sasso Caveoso. I was nine years old when the State made us leave. I came back in 1996. Fifty years later.

I'll tell you about Matera the way someone tells you about a place they've lived inside. Not the way books describe it.

### CAP. 2 — WHAT THE SASSI ARE

The word sassi might seem odd to you. In Italian, sasso means stone. But here the Sassi are the neighbourhoods — Sasso Barisano and Sasso Caveoso — the two basins carved on either side of the Civita, the central hill where the Cathedral stands.

The dwellings are called ipogei. Caves. Not built — carved. The rock you see everywhere is calcareous tufa, a soft stone that can be cut with chisels and hardens over time like concrete.

The oldest homes are completely inside the rock. The more recent ones — from the last five centuries or so — have a built facade in front of the cave entrance. A facade with a window, a door, maybe a balcony. And behind it, the cave.

My mother always said: our house had three rooms. One was inside the rock, one was built out front, and one was the sky.

Because the open courtyards here aren't empty space. They're a room without a roof. People lived in them, worked in them, slept in them in summer.

### **CAP. 3 — WATER: THE SYSTEM THAT KEPT MATERA ALIVE**

Before anything else, you need to understand the water.

Matera sits on a tufa plateau with no rivers, no springs, no natural wells. The only water was rain.

Over seven thousand years, the inhabitants of the Sassi developed the most sophisticated water system of the ancient world.

Under every house there is a cistern. Carved into rock, coated with *cocciopesto* — a mix of lime and crushed terracotta that seals out water. The roofs are angled to channel rainwater into gutters. The gutters carry it to the cisterns. The cisterns hold it for months.

But there's more. The cisterns are connected through the rock. When one fills up, the overflow passes to the next. A system of communicating vessels running beneath the entire Sasso.

Under Sasso Caveoso there are hundreds of cisterns still intact. Some as large as gymnasiums. Many haven't been fully explored yet.

When I was a little girl going to fetch water with my mother, I'd climb down a narrow staircase cut into the rock and arrive in this dark, cool space where the water reflected the candle flame. It felt like magic. It was two-thousand-year-old engineering.

### **CAP. 4 — LIFE IN THE SASSI: WHAT IT WAS REALLY LIKE**

Let me tell you what life was really like here. Not the way history books tell it.

Our cave had one room. About forty square metres. In it lived my grandmother, my mother, my father, five children, and a donkey.

The donkey is not a joke. Animals slept with the families. There was no other option — a stable would have been another cave to carve, and whoever had a stable was wealthy. We were not wealthy.

My parents' bed was on a raised platform. We children slept underneath, next to the donkey. In winter, the animal's warmth heated the whole cave.

There was no electricity until the 1950s. No running water. No sewage. The latrine was a hole in the rock.

And yet.

And yet I remember that cave with something that isn't shame. I remember the cool air in summer, when it was forty-two degrees outside and twenty inside the rock. I remember darkness that didn't frighten you because it was a familiar darkness, full of voices. I remember the community — where an open door onto the courtyard meant you could come in.

It wasn't good. But it was alive.

## **CAP. 5 — THE SHAME OF ITALY: THE EVACUATION**

In 1945 a Lucanian writer named Carlo Levi published a book. It was called *Christ Stopped at Eboli*. It wasn't about Matera specifically — it was about his confinement in Lucania, about the poverty of the South. But the image it gave the world was of a forgotten South, abandoned by history.

Then in 1948, Prime Minister Alcide De Gasperi visited Matera. He saw the caves, he saw the families, he saw the children.

The following year, Communist Party leader Palmiro Togliatti gave a speech in Matera and from the piazza he declared: "This is the shame of Italy."

And from that moment, for forty years, that was what Matera was — the shame of Italy.

In 1952 the Colombo Law was passed. Mandatory evacuation of the Sassi. By 1963 fifteen thousand people had been forcibly relocated to new housing blocks on the plateau.

My turn came in 1957. I was nine. My father loaded what we had onto a cart — the mattress, the pots, some clothes. And we walked down. We didn't look back. Or maybe we did, but I don't remember.

The new house had two separate rooms, a bathroom, running water. My mother cried for a week. I don't know if it was relief or grief. Probably both.

## **CAP. 6 — THE ROCK CHURCHES: THE ART NO ONE LOOKS FOR**

Now let me take you somewhere most visitors never see.

In the Sassi there are over one hundred rupestrian churches. Churches carved into rock by Benedictine and Basilian monks between the seventh and thirteenth centuries.

These monks came from the East — from Syria, from Palestine, from Cappadocia. They were fleeing persecution, seeking solitude, and they found Matera's caves perfect for monastic life.

And inside these caves, they left frescoes.

Colours that are still vivid after a thousand years — red, ultramarine blue, ochre. Saints with wide-open eyes watching you from the dark rock. Madonna and child, Christ Pantocrator, local saints the books know nothing about.

The most famous is the Madonna de Idris, carved into the rock of the same name rising from the middle of Sasso Caveoso. But there are lesser-known ones where you're practically alone, with a torch and silence.

If you step inside one of these churches and wait for your eyes to adjust to the dark, you'll start to understand why the monks chose this place. It's not just the coolness. It's something in the rock itself — a presence. I don't know what else to call it.

## **CAP. 7 — THE CATHEDRAL AND THE CIVITA**

Walk uphill now. Toward the Civita.

The Civita is the hill that divides the two Sassi — Barisano on the left, Caveoso on the right. On this hill was the original settlement, the first nucleus of habitation that then spread downward on both sides.

At the top is the Cathedral. Built between 1230 and 1270, in Apulian Romanesque style. The white facade that gleams in the morning sun can be seen from the whole city — it's Matera's visual landmark.

Inside the Cathedral is the Madonna della Bruna. The patron saint of Matera. Her feast is celebrated every year on 2 July with a procession on a triumphal float that ends with something unique — the faithful storm the float and tear it apart.

It's not vandalism. It's a ritual. Whoever brings home a piece of the float brings good luck for a year. The Madonna is rescued before the assault. The float is sacrificed.

Matera recognises itself in this — something sacred that ends in destruction and is rebuilt again each year. Like the Sassi themselves.

## **CAP. 8 — THE MURGIA: THE SIDE NO ONE CALCULATES**

Cross the ravine.

On the opposite side from the Sassi is the Murgia Materana Park. A plateau of limestone rock and Mediterranean scrubland that faces Matera from across the gorge.

From there, the view is incomprehensible.

You see the entire city carved into the hillside, and for the first time you understand how it's really built. How the houses climb the rock, how the bell towers emerge from the weave of caves, how the Cathedral dominates everything from the top of the Civita.

But the Murgia isn't just a viewpoint. It's a landscape with three thousand years of history. There are rupestrian churches there too — the Crypt of Original Sin, with eighth-century frescoes that UNESCO has called the Sistine Chapel of rupestrian painting.

There are Neolithic hilltop villages. Bronze Age pit graves. Traces of settlements that predate the Sassi by millennia.

Matera's history doesn't begin with the Sassi. The Sassi are almost recent, if you use the right scale.

## **CAP. 9 — UNESCO AND THE RETURN**

In 1993 something happened that none of us had foreseen.

UNESCO inscribed the Sassi of Matera on the World Heritage List.

Not the shame of Italy. The heritage of humanity.

Overnight, the judgment on the place where I was born had been reversed. What had been erased as backward, as poor, as unworthy — had become a precious thing to preserve.

The 1990s were the decade of returns. Families who had been evicted came back to buy the caves they had left behind. The caves were cheap — nobody wanted them. But some people could see.

I came back in 1996. Not to my mother's cave — that belonged to others by then. To another one, not far away. I restored it, slowly, with what I had.

The first night I slept in the rock again after forty years, I understood that I had never quite felt at home anywhere else. As if all the time spent away had only been a wait.

## **CAP. 10 — MATERA 2019 AND TODAY**

In 2019 Matera was European Capital of Culture.

It's a strange thing to explain to someone who doesn't know the history. A city that fifty years earlier had been evacuated by law as a place unfit for human habitation — became the cultural capital of Europe.

2019 brought tourists, concerts, installations, artists from all over the world. It also brought speculation, restaurant prices tripled, guesthouses with caves turned into suites with jacuzzis.

I don't complain. I'd take this any day over being forgotten. I'd rather people come and look than forget this place exists.

But there's a Matera that still exists behind the tourism. The lanes of Sasso Barisano at noon, when the tourists are resting. Piazza Vittorio Veneto early in the morning, with the old men having their coffee. Children playing on the steps of the Civita the way I used to play.

That Matera is still here. You just have to know when to look.

## **CAP. 11 — WHAT TO EAT AND WHERE**

Matera bread carries the IGP quality mark. It's made from Senatore Cappelli durum wheat, baked in a wood-fired oven, with a hard crust that keeps for days and a yellow, fragrant crumb. It comes in a distinctive shape — a horn or a tall loaf — and weighs one to two kilos. You don't buy it by the slice. You take it home whole.

Crapinata is a mixed legume soup — broad beans, chickpeas, lentils, grass peas, white beans — made on the first Monday in August as it has been for centuries in this area. Every family has their recipe. Every recipe is the best.

The crusco pepper is another Matera thing — peppers dried and then fried in hot oil until they go crisp like crisps. They get crumbled over bread, pasta, everything.

To eat well without spending a fortune, look for trattorias in the side lanes of Sasso Barisano. Not the ones with menus translated into five languages. The ones with a hand-written chalkboard and an owner who asks where you're from.

## **CAP. 12 — CLOSING: ROSA SAYS GOODBYE**

Seventy-eight years old. Born in a cave. Forced to leave. Chose to come back.

When people ask me if I'm angry at the State for making us go, I think for a moment. And then I say: no.

Those conditions were not dignified. Children fell ill. Malaria was still a reality. Women spent their lives carrying water. Leaving was necessary.

But the way it was done — forced, without explanation, without respect — that was not right. Nobody was asked. Nobody was given time to say goodbye. We were told to go, and we went.

Matera is beautiful now. Maybe too polished in places. But it's alive. And that's what matters.

If you stop here for a moment, anywhere in the Sassi, and close your eyes — you feel something. I don't know if it's the wind in the ravine, or the weight of history, or simply the rock breathing.

But you feel it.

Thank you for coming. Take the time you need. Matera doesn't work if you rush it.